

Cavendish Cards

FACILITATOR SHEET

A deck for naming sensory and niche-construction needs. Point at a card, or lay a few. No reading needed to play.

Two rules hold the whole thing up.

- **No scoring.** No points, no matching, no right answer, no winning. There is no wrong card and no wrong hand.
- **The person controls sharing.** Turning a card up is the person sharing it; the turn is the consent. You don't turn their cards over for them.

Seven ways to play

Show me — *early years, anyone*

Pick the one card that's you right now. That's the whole game. Say back what you see: "Buzzy today. Okay." Under a minute.

Build my day — *a person and a facilitator*

Lay a place, a weather, and a couple of what-helps cards. A sentence in pictures — *the cave, buzzy, headphones*. You've been handed a design brief. Build the conditions. Two to five minutes.

Class weather — *a whole group*

Everyone lays a weather card face-up. The room's weather becomes visible. No one is named. Nothing is scored. Two minutes, and the group has a shared word for the day.

Map the edges — *older learners, or a group*

Every day has edges — the jumps between one thing and the next, where a mind in deep focus gets yanked to something new. Those crossings are where the day gets hard, and the strain is the *jump*, not the person. Lay the day out left to right, then find its edges: focus → talking, rest → joining in, home → out the door. On each edge that bites, lay a lily pad — *slowly, not yet, i need a minute, coming back* — the stepping stone that would let you land gently instead of being pulled across. A what-helps card can pad a crossing too: *tell me first* is the one that most often does. You're not mapping what's wrong with you; you're padding the crossings so the day fits. Designed *with* the person, never *at* them. Ten to fifteen minutes.

Play as the environment — *staff training*

Deal a table of what-helps cards with needs that conflict — room to move against less talking, just one person against a full group. Build one habitat that holds them all. You'll feel neurological pluralism instead of hearing about it. Twenty minutes.

Moving between — *anyone, across a day*

Lay places, interaction moods, and lily pads left to right — the cave, ready now, the campfire, i need a minute, back again. A rhythm of alone and together, mapped in cards. Move one when the rhythm shifts. This is intermittent collaboration: nobody stays in one place all day.

Build a niche — *a learner, or a group*

Lay the what-helps that would make a space fit you — a den, less to look at, the right temperature — with the habitat card at the center. A design brief for the room, not a snapshot of a day. Then build it, on any budget — Zone a room works out which zones the space can already hold, and prints signs for the door.

Sharing belongs to the person

The turn of a card is the consent. It plays out three ways:

- **Kept** — the spread stays face-down. Nothing is read until the person turns something up.
- **Shown by invitation** — the person hands the spread to one person they pick. A deliberate act, not standing permission.
- **Ambient only** — in group play, only the room's weather shows. No individual's cards, ever.

Interaction cards are the exception — they're made to be shown.

In the web deck that choice is two buttons. **Copy for a journal** is the whole spread — the date, the questions, the note box — and it belongs to the person. **Copy to share** is the cards alone. Ask for the shared one by name: it leaves out the note, the date, and the interaction, kind words and grower cards, which are worn or kept rather than sent.

When a person lays "stuck"

Stuck is a lily pad. It's a place to land, not a failure. Read it as information: something in the environment isn't fitting yet. Don't push the person across. Ask what would help them land — or offer a what-helps card and let them choose.

How to respond, in three moves

- 1 **Mirror it back.** Name what you see, plainly. No praise, no fixing, no interrogation.
- 2 **Reach for the environment, not the person.** A card is a request to change the conditions. Change them.
- 3 **Leave the sharing with the person.** What they turn up is theirs to turn up.

A pile of spreads after an event

Nobody can hold twenty spreads in their head. Group access needs turns a pile into one short brief for the room, written so you can hand that page to whatever AI you already use and have it do the sorting — under rules that keep the room as the subject and never count anybody. Merge and strip first; the page says what to take out, and why.

If it's not working, it's not the person.

Not an AAC board. It sits alongside a person's real communication system and never replaces it; a spread cannot carry somebody's words. Why that matters.

Not a screening tool. A spread is the person telling you something — not you assessing them. No pathology paradigm, no deficit ideology, no behaviorism, no emotional sorting: a card names a need, never a symptom, a target, or a level.

Broken systems, not broken people. The deck exists so a person can shape the space around them — and so the people beside them can read what they need without asking a person to explain in words they may not have.